ViBridge-VQA: Bridging Global and Local Visual Tokens for Parameter-Efficient Vietnamese Visual Question Answering

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Abstract. Vision–language models (VLMs) such as Vintern-1B bring strong multimodal abilities to Vietnamese. However, adapting them to a new Visual Question Answering (VQA) benchmark usually requires fine-tuning on many high-resolution image tiles or training a new architecture. We propose **ViBridge-VQA**, which improves Vintern-1B without updating any of its pre-trained weights. From a single image view, the frozen decoder receives two kinds of visual tokens. *Global* tokens are produced from the `[CLS]` vector by a small trainable bridge. *Local* tokens come from Vintern-1B's own pre-aligned projector and are pooled to a budget chosen as the knee of the accuracy–cost Pareto front. On the reasoning-oriented AutoViVQA benchmark, ViBridge-VQA trains 1.35% of the parameters and reaches 54.6 F1, comparable to the fine-tuned Vintern-1B, with 36 times fewer visual tokens. A lightweight decoder LoRA raises F1 to 58.2. Reusing the pre-trained projector is more effective than learning a new connector. The local tokens also complement decoder adaptation and transfer to three other Vietnamese VQA datasets.

Keywords: Vietnamese Visual Question Answering · Vision–Language Models · Parameter-Efficient Learning · Visual Token Budget · Generative VQA

1 Introduction

Visual Question Answering (VQA) asks a model to answer a natural-language question about an image. Large vision–language models (VLMs) such as BLIP-2 [12], Flamingo [1] and LLaVA [19] have advanced the task rapidly. They connect a pre-trained vision encoder to a pre-trained language model and generate free-form answers. Vietnamese has followed this trend. The open model Vintern-1B [7] connects an InternViT-300M encoder [6] to a Qwen2.5-0.5B decoder [26]. Benchmarks such as ViVQA [29] and the reasoning-oriented AutoViVQA [21] measure progress in this low-resource setting.

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However, building a strong model for a new Vietnamese benchmark is still expensive. The common recipe fine-tunes an existing VLM. The fine-tuned Vintern-1B baseline of AutoViVQA adds LoRA adapters to the language model and splits each image into up to six high-resolution tiles plus a thumbnail. Its decoder thus reads up to 1,792 visual tokens per image. Another option is a task-specific architecture, such as ViMoE-VQA [20] with its sparse mixture-of-experts fusion module. A cheaper option keeps the whole VLM frozen and trains only a small connector. Existing connectors follow two designs. A *global-only bridge* maps the global image vector to a few tokens. It is cheap, but it loses local details such as small objects, printed text and spatial relations. A *learned patch compressor*, such as a Q-Former, keeps these details. However, it must learn a new mapping from visual features to the decoder, which is difficult with limited Vietnamese data.

Vintern-1B already offers a third option. Its projector was pre-trained to map image regions into the input space of the decoder, so this alignment does not need to be learned again. Meanwhile, the model discards the global `[CLS]` vector of its encoder, which summarises the whole scene. We therefore study two questions. With limited labelled data, is reusing the pre-trained alignment of a VLM more effective than learning a new connector? And how many global and local tokens does the frozen decoder need?

To this end, we propose **ViBridge-VQA**. It gives the frozen decoder of Vintern-1B two complementary kinds of visual tokens from a single image view. *Local* tokens reuse the frozen projector, average-pooled to a chosen budget and placed in the original image slot. The decoder thus receives region features in the representation it was trained to read. *Global* tokens are produced from the `[CLS]` vector by a small trainable bridge, the only trained part. They add the scene-level information that Vintern-1B ignores. Since every additional token increases inference cost, we treat the number of tokens as a budget. We select it as the knee of the accuracy–cost Pareto front. ViBridge-VQA performs on par with the fine-tuned Vintern-1B without updating any of its weights, while its decoder reads far fewer visual tokens.

In summary, our main contributions are as follows:

- We propose **ViBridge-VQA**, a global–local bridge for a frozen Vietnamese VLM. It combines trainable global tokens with local tokens from the VLM's own pre-trained projector, and it can be combined with a lightweight decoder LoRA.
- We treat the number of visual tokens as an explicit **accuracy–cost budget**, selected on validation as the knee of the Pareto front.
- We **analyse where the gains come from**. Local tokens matter more than global ones, and reusing the projector beats learning a new connector. Local tokens also complement decoder adaptation and transfer to other Vietnamese VQA datasets.

2 Related Work

Early VQA systems classified over a fixed answer set. Current generative VLMs instead produce free-form answers with an autoregressive language model [12,1,19]. Vietnamese VQA datasets include ViVQA [29], the synthetic ViCLEVR [31], the book-cover ViOCRVQA [25] and the scene-text ViTextVQA [23]. AutoViVQA [21] contributes 37,077 questions on 19,411 COCO images [17]. Its questions are generated by large language models, filtered by an ensemble of validators and annotated with reasoning categories. On the modelling side, BARTPhoBEiT [30] and AViVQA-TranConI [22] combine pre-trained visual and Vietnamese language representations. Vintern-1B [7] brings an instruction-tuned VLM to Vietnamese. ViMoE-VQA [20] routes multimodal tokens to sparse experts for generative VQA on AutoViVQA. AutoViVQA and ViMoE-VQA are earlier work of our group. Here we use the AutoViVQA data but no component of ViMoE-VQA, and the method, the image-disjoint split and all results are new. These approaches either train a new model or fine-tune a VLM on multi-tile inputs. In contrast, we keep every pre-trained weight of Vintern-1B frozen and use a single image view.

Training only a connector between a frozen vision encoder and a frozen language model is a common way to build VLMs efficiently. Connectors differ mainly in what they must learn. Frozen [32] learns a visual prefix from a global image representation. The Q-Former of BLIP-2 [12] learns queries that compress the patch features. It preserves details but is a large module (188M parameters) pre-trained on millions of image–text pairs. LLaVA [19,18] projects every patch token with a small MLP. This preserves locality but passes hundreds of tokens to the decoder. Honeybee [4] proposes locality-preserving abstractors. InternVL [6], on which Vintern-1B is built, merges neighbouring patches before its MLP projector. In all of these models, the mapping from patches to the decoder is learned during large-scale pre-training. ViBridge-VQA does not learn this local mapping again. It reuses the projector already pre-trained in the VLM and trains only a small global bridge (12.9M parameters) on about 26k task questions.

The number of visual tokens largely determines the cost of the decoder. Inference-optimal scaling of VLMs [13] shows that a few tokens can suffice for many tasks. Matryoshka multimodal models [3] work at several nested pooled budgets and show that the required budget depends on the task. Other work reduces the visual tokens directly. DeCo [34] replaces the Q-Former with adaptive average pooling of the patch tokens and reports better results. TokenPacker [14] learns a compact projector, while LLaVA-PruMerge [28] and FastV [5] prune or merge the visual tokens of an existing model. Like DeCo, we use simple average pooling. However, we apply it to the output of an already pre-trained projector and keep the whole VLM frozen. We also choose the budget with explicit criteria: the knee of the Pareto front [27] and TOPSIS [11]. Parameter-efficient methods such as adapters [9], prefix tuning [15] and LoRA [10] reduce the cost of adaptation from the other side. They train a small number of additional weights in the decoder. We use decoder LoRA both as a baseline and as a complement. We ask whether a small training budget is better spent on the visual tokens or on adapting the decoder.

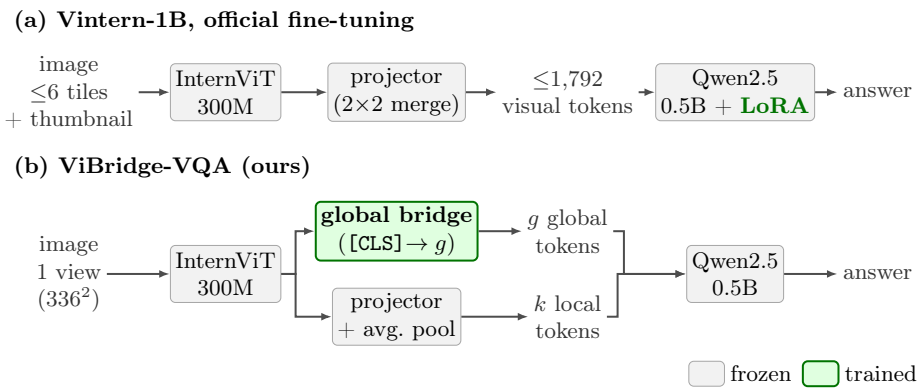


Fig. 1: Overview of (a) the official fine-tuning of Vintern-1B, which encodes up to seven views, and (b) ViBridge-VQA, which encodes one view and passes g global and k local tokens to the frozen decoder (selected: $g = 14$, $k = 36$).

3 Proposed Method

We formulate VQA as conditional answer generation. Given an image I and a Vietnamese question q, the model generates a short free-form answer $y = (y_1, \ldots, y_T)$. ViBridge-VQA builds on Vintern-1B [7] and keeps all of its pre-trained weights frozen. Instead of adapting the model, it changes the visual input of its decoder.

3.1 Overall Architecture

As shown in Fig. 1, ViBridge-VQA keeps the three components of Vintern-1B: the InternViT-300M vision encoder (24 layers, width 1024), its two-layer MLP projector P, and the Qwen2.5-0.5B-Instruct decoder (24 layers, width 896). Each image is resized to one 336×336 view, i.e., 24×24 patches of 14×14 pixels. InternViT was pre-trained at 448×448 and bicubically interpolates its position embeddings to this resolution. This roughly halves the encoder cost (191 instead of 362 GMACs per view). The encoder returns one vector per patch and a global `[CLS]` vector $v \in \mathbb{R}^{1024}$. Vintern-1B uses only the patch vectors. It merges every 2×2 block of neighbouring patches into one 4096-dimensional vector (pixel shuffle). The projector P, pre-trained to align the two backbones, maps each merged vector into the decoder input space. At our resolution, this yields a 12×12 grid of 144 region tokens. ViBridge-VQA uses both outputs of the encoder.

3.2 Global Tokens

The `[CLS]` vector summarises the whole scene, but Vintern-1B never passes it to the decoder. A small trainable bridge g_ϕ expands it into g tokens with two linear heads:

$$g_\phi(v) = \left[\, W_a v + b_a;\ \mathrm{reshape}_{(g-1)\times 896}(W_e v + b_e) \,\right] \in \mathbb{R}^{g \times 896}. \tag{1}$$

where $W_a \in \mathbb{R}^{896\times1024}$ and $W_e \in \mathbb{R}^{(g-1)896\times1024}$. The first head produces an *anchor* token. The second produces $g-1$ complementary tokens that present the global content from different learned directions. The bridge has $1025 \cdot 896 \cdot g$ parameters, i.e., 12,857,600 for $g = 14$. Its g tokens are placed before the prompt. We consider $g \in \{8, 14\}$. Our Global-only model uses $g = 8$, which matches the eight learned queries of the Tile-Attention and light Q-Former bridges it is compared with (Section 4.4). Beyond $g = 14$, F1 stops increasing when the Global-only bridge is varied from 4 to 20 tokens (Section 4.5). The final pair (g, k) is selected with the criterion of Section 3.5.

3.3 Local Tokens

To give the decoder region-level detail, ViBridge-VQA also passes local tokens. They are taken directly from the 144 region tokens of the frozen projector P. To control their number, we average-pool the 12×12 grid to an $s \times s$ grid, so that $k = s^2$ with $s \in \{1, 3, 6, 12\}$. Thus $k = 144$ keeps every region token, and $k = 36$ averages each 2×2 block. The pooled tokens replace the embeddings of k image-context placeholders inside Vintern-1B's own image slot, `<img>` $\cdots$ `</img>`, in the prompt. They come from the pre-trained projector rather than from a newly learned projection. The local tokens therefore stay in the representation that the decoder was trained to read, and no parameters are needed to produce them.

3.4 Training Objective

Only the bridge parameters ϕ are trained. The vision encoder, the projector and the decoder remain frozen, and no adapter is added to the decoder. We minimise the cross-entropy of the answer tokens:

$$\mathcal{L} = -\sum_{t=1}^{T} \log p\big(y_t \mid y_{<t},\, g_\phi(v),\, \mathrm{pool}_s(P(x)),\, q\big), \tag{2}$$

where x denotes the merged patch vectors. ViBridge-VQA can also be combined with decoder adaptation. In that variant, a rank-16 LoRA [10] on the query, key, value and output projections of every decoder layer is trained jointly with the bridge. It adds 2,162,688 parameters. Throughout the paper, percentages of trained parameters are relative to all parameters of the model. These are the frozen components of Vintern-1B (about 0.94B, including the vision encoder, projector, embeddings and output layer) plus the trained modules. With $g = 14$, the bridge alone trains 12.86M parameters (1.35%), and the bridge with LoRA 15.02M (1.57%).

3.5 Choosing the Token Budget

The cost of the decoder grows with the number of visual tokens $g+k$. We therefore treat the pair (g, k) as a budget to be chosen. In our experiments, F1 increases

with every added token among the configurations with local tokens. All of them thus lie on the accuracy–token Pareto front, and the front alone does not single one out. We therefore select its *knee* [27], the point after which additional tokens bring diminishing returns. We first normalise cost c and accuracy a to $[0, 1]$ over the front. The knee is the configuration that maximises $\hat{a} - \hat{c}$, i.e., the one furthest above the line joining the cheapest and the most accurate configuration. The knee is computed on the validation split only. We check the choice with the multi-criteria method TOPSIS [11], also on validation. Test results are computed for every configuration only to be reported, and no choice is based on them.

4 Experiments

4.1 Dataset and Evaluation Metrics

Dataset. We use AutoViVQA [21], a Vietnamese VQA benchmark built on MS COCO images [17]. Each question has five short free-form answers and a reasoning type. We remove 273 duplicated (image, question) pairs and 97 questions without a reasoning label. The remaining 36,707 questions are split 70/15/15 by image (seed 42), so no test image is seen in training. This gives 25,776 / 5,463 / 5,468 questions on 13,579 / 2,909 / 2,910 images. The split is stricter than a question-level split: it lowers the F1 of Global-only by about 0.5 points.

Metrics. Following AutoViVQA and ViMoE-VQA, we report Accuracy (exact match), word-level Precision, Recall and F1, BLEU [24], ROUGE-L [16], METEOR [2] and CIDEr [33]. All metrics are computed against the five reference answers.

4.2 Experimental Setup

Implementation details. The vision encoder, projector and decoder come from Vintern-1B-v3.5 [7] and stay frozen. We train with AdamW (learning rate 2×10^{-4}, effective batch size 8) on the first reference answer. ViBridge-VQA is trained for two epochs, after which the validation loss and CIDEr stop improving. Variants with a decoder LoRA are trained for one joint epoch. Global-only + LoRA is also trained for three epochs, its best setting (+1.3 validation F1). Decoding is greedy, with at most 50 new tokens. Each configuration is trained with three seeds (42, 123, 3407), and we report the mean ± std. Every model fits on one 16 GB NVIDIA T4. The token budget is selected on validation, and the test split is used only for the final report.

Baselines. We compare with three groups. (1) Multimodal models fine-tuned on AutoViVQA: ViT5_ViT, BARTPhoBEiT [30], Vintern-1B and ViMoE-VQA [20]. (2) Zero-shot models: Vintern-1B, LLaMA 3.2, Gemini 2.0 and 2.5 Flash, and GPT-5. Results of groups (1) and (2) are taken from the AutoViVQA and

Table 1: Performance comparison on the AutoViVQA test set. Baseline results are taken from AutoViVQA [21] and ViMoE-VQA [20]; ours are the mean ± std over three seeds. Best results per column are in bold. All values ×100.

	Model	Accuracy	Precision	Recall	F1	BLEU	ROUGE-L	METEOR	CIDEr
Fine-tuned	ViT5_ViT	7.97	46.84	50.33	48.52	4.13	46.89	31.02	72.68
	BARTPhoBEiT	8.81	45.30	46.48	45.88	4.33	44.83	24.57	**188.96**
	Vintern-1B	13.01	52.47	55.12	53.76	6.11	51.93	35.25	72.84
	ViMoE-VQA	9.55	**62.89**	58.60	**60.69**	12.54	47.12	39.10	88.76
Zero-shot	Vintern-1B	0.12	17.52	19.87	17.55	1.91	25.84	23.93	8.54
	LLaMA 3.2	0.36	23.96	73.71	36.16	3.62	36.11	30.01	62.84
	Gemini 2.0 F.	0.55	27.20	74.10	39.79	4.41	39.60	31.72	74.42
	Gemini 2.5 F.	0.22	24.43	**76.66**	24.75	0.39	37.27	31.22	71.90
	GPT-5	10.84	47.20	55.20	50.89	6.07	47.30	33.34	84.20
Ours	ViBridge-VQA (k=36)	11.75 ±0.21	55.36 ±0.21	56.56 ±0.21	54.56 ±0.19	18.52 ±0.18	52.64 ±0.19	45.53 ±0.33	110.58 ±0.95
	ViBridge-VQA (k=36) + LoRA	**14.67** ±0.30	59.02 ±0.12	59.96 ±0.33	58.17 ±0.19	**22.53** ±0.11	**56.25** ±0.22	**49.32** ±0.37	122.88 ±0.93

ViMoE-VQA papers. The fine-tuned Vintern-1B uses the official recipe: up to six 448×448 tiles plus a thumbnail, and a rank-16 LoRA on the language model for one epoch. (3) *Global-only*: the Multi-Token bridge of Eq. (1) with $g = 8$ and no local tokens, without and with a decoder LoRA (*Global-only + LoRA*). Our models are *ViBridge-VQA (k=36)*, with $g = 14$, and *ViBridge-VQA (k=36) + LoRA*.

4.3 Main Results

Table 1 compares ViBridge-VQA with the baselines. Without updating any weight of Vintern-1B, ViBridge-VQA raises its F1 from 17.55 (zero-shot) to 54.56. This is comparable to the fine-tuned Vintern-1B (53.76), with 50 instead of 1,792 visual tokens and only 1.35% of the parameters trained. Only Accuracy is lower (11.75 versus 13.01).

Adding a decoder LoRA raises F1 to 58.17 (+3.61), with 1.57% of the parameters trained. It also gives the best Accuracy (14.67), BLEU (22.53), ROUGE-L (56.25) and METEOR (49.32). ViMoE-VQA, which trains its fusion module and decoder on AutoViVQA, keeps the best Precision and F1. With the same one-epoch LoRA, ViBridge-VQA is 4.74 validation F1 above Global-only (58.21 versus 53.47, Table 2).

Results are stable across seeds. On test, the std is at most 0.19 for F1 and 0.95 for CIDEr, and test F1 is within 0.6 of validation F1.

4.4 Source of the Visual Tokens

Table 2 compares three sources of visual tokens: the `[CLS]` vector (*Residual* and *Multi-Token*), learned compressions of the patches (*Tile-Attention*, light and full Q-Former [12]), and our local tokens from the pre-trained projector.

Reusing the projector works best. Without LoRA, the learned compressions stay 3.7–5.6 F1 below Multi-Token, despite up to 9.4× more parameters. In contrast,

Table 2: Comparison of visual-token sources on the validation set (mean ± std over three seeds, four for Multi-Token). Params: trained bridge parameters. Best results per block are in bold. All values ×100.

Visual tokens from	Tokens	Params	F1	BLEU	ROUGE-L	METEOR	CIDEr
Bridge only (two epochs)							
Residual	1	4.86M	46.02 ±.36	12.98 ±.15	44.23 ±.38	36.86 ±.31	86.48 ±.77
Multi-Token	8	7.35M	50.74 ±.17	16.88 ±.23	49.03 ±.12	41.38 ±.21	99.07 ±.47
Tile-Attention	8	4.14M	45.14 ±.92	12.34 ±.32	43.28 ±.95	36.11 ±.73	84.14 ±1.40
Light Q-Former	8	27.6M	47.06 ±.66	13.99 ±.33	45.37 ±.63	37.57 ±.60	88.07 ±1.89
Full Q-Former	16	69.4M	46.84 ±.47	13.76 ±.36	45.10 ±.41	37.43 ±.34	87.74 ±1.24
ViBridge-VQA (k=36)	50	12.86M	**54.96** ±.28	**18.73** ±.23	**53.10** ±.27	**46.01** ±.42	**113.29** ±1.01
+ decoder LoRA (one joint epoch, 2.16M parameters)							
Residual	1	4.86M	52.69 ±.14	18.94 ±.36	51.04 ±.13	43.33 ±.33	104.25 ±.93
Multi-Token	8	7.35M	53.47 ±.17	19.72 ±.09	51.79 ±.15	44.11 ±.23	106.68 ±.69
Tile-Attention	8	4.14M	52.80 ±.06	19.27 ±.16	51.16 ±.06	43.41 ±.05	104.81 ±.14
Light Q-Former	8	27.6M	53.21 ±.14	19.92 ±.31	51.54 ±.13	43.77 ±.19	106.26 ±.73
Full Q-Former	16	69.4M	53.29 ±.29	19.57 ±.25	51.62 ±.30	43.96 ±.21	106.50 ±1.04
ViBridge-VQA (k=36)	50	12.86M	**58.21** ±.16	**22.27** ±.17	**56.42** ±.14	**49.55** ±.06	**124.88** ±.75

adding 36 or 144 local tokens to Multi-Token ($g = 8$) raises F1 by 3.58 and 5.41 (Table 3). We also tried to distil the projector into Global-only. A cosine loss between the mean tokens of the bridge and of the projector gives 50.35 F1. A KL loss between the answer distributions obtained with each gives 50.46 F1. Both stay below 50.74 without distillation.

Local tokens and LoRA are complementary. With a decoder LoRA, all bridges without local tokens reach 52.69–53.47 F1. They still stay below ViBridge-VQA with a frozen decoder (54.96). The same LoRA adds 3.25 F1 to ViBridge-VQA, more than the 2.73 it adds to Multi-Token.

4.5 Visual Token Budget

Local tokens matter more than global tokens. Table 3 and Fig. 2a vary $g \in \{8, 14\}$ and $k \in \{1, 9, 36, 144\}$. At $g = 14$, going from 1 to 144 local tokens adds 4.94 F1 and 19.05 CIDEr. Going from 8 to 14 global tokens adds only 0.2–0.8 F1 at a fixed k. The gain per token falls from 0.07 F1 (23 to 50 tokens) to 0.015 F1 (50 to 158 tokens).

Selected budget. F1 grows with every added token, so all configurations with local tokens lie on the accuracy–token Pareto front. Its knee (Section 3.5) is $g = 14$, $k = 36$ for every metric. The knee is the same with evaluation time as the cost, although times differ by only minutes below $k = 144$. TOPSIS with equal weights and the post-hoc knee on test also select this budget. $k = 144$ is 1.65 F1 higher, but $k = 36$ obtains 72% of its gain over Global-only with 32% of its tokens. Against the 14-token Global-only bridge, the 36 local tokens add 3.40 F1 (51.56 to 54.96), or 67% of the gain of $k = 144$.

Table 3: Effect of the token budget on the validation set (mean ± std over three seeds, four for $g = 8$, $k = 0$). Time: minutes to evaluate validation and test on one T4. The selected budget is in bold. All values ×100.

g	k	Tokens	Time	F1	BLEU	ROUGE-L	METEOR	CIDEr
8	0	8	–	50.74 ±.17	16.88 ±.23	49.03 ±.12	41.38 ±.21	99.07 ±.47
14	0	14	–	51.56 ±.08	17.76 ±.01	49.86 ±.05	42.14 ±.17	101.18 ±.52
8	1	9	57.0	51.03 ±.12	16.54 ±.27	49.21 ±.13	41.37 ±.11	99.27 ±.58
8	9	17	59.2	52.82 ±.11	17.58 ±.03	50.96 ±.05	43.56 ±.20	106.11 ±.55
8	36	44	60.6	54.32 ±.41	18.22 ±.39	52.48 ±.43	45.31 ±.42	111.88 ±1.43
8	144	152	71.2	56.15 ±.08	19.82 ±.00	54.21 ±.06	47.51 ±.05	119.05 ±.25
14	1	15	58.8	51.67 ±.25	17.30 ±.36	49.93 ±.24	42.36 ±.19	101.66 ±1.11
14	9	23	57.7	52.98 ±.08	17.83 ±.23	51.17 ±.10	43.71 ±.13	106.02 ±.80
14	**36**	**50**	**60.0**	**54.96** ±.28	**18.73** ±.23	**53.10** ±.27	**46.01** ±.42	**113.29** ±1.01
14	144	158	70.2	56.61 ±.04	20.18 ±.13	54.70 ±.05	48.00 ±.05	120.71 ±.12

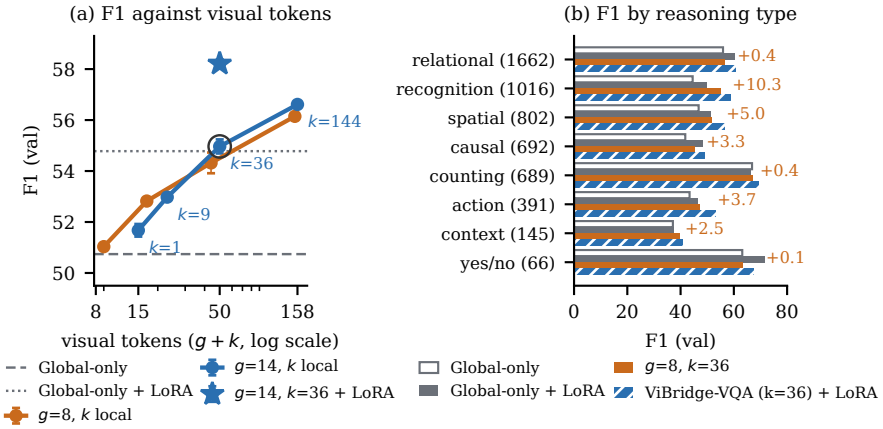


Fig. 2: (a) Validation F1 against the number of visual tokens (circle: selected budget). (b) Validation F1 by reasoning type (number of questions); numbers: gain of 36 local tokens at $g = 8$.

Number of global tokens. We varied the Multi-Token bridge from $g = 4$ to $g = 20$ (three seeds, two for $g = 20$). Validation F1 rises from 48.98 ($g = 4$) to 50.74 ($g = 8$) and 51.56 ($g = 14$). It then stays between 51.20 and 51.60 for $g = 16$–20.

Computational cost. The decoder reads 50 visual tokens, against 1,792 for the official tiling (seven views per test image). The encoder processes one 336×336 view (191 GMACs) instead of seven 448×448 views (362 GMACs each), 13 times less computation. Within our budgets, $k = 144$ instead of $k = 36$ makes evaluation about 17% slower.



Fig. 3: Qualitative examples from the validation set. GT: one of the five reference answers; Ours: ViBridge-VQA (k=36); Ours+LoRA: ViBridge-VQA (k=36) + LoRA.

4.6 Analysis

Reasoning types. Fig. 2b breaks down validation F1 by reasoning type. Local tokens help most when the answer is visible in the image. At $g = 8$, 36 local tokens add 10.3 F1 on recognition, 5.0 on spatial and 3.7 on action questions. On these types, the frozen-decoder model even beats Global-only + LoRA. Decoder adaptation helps more on yes/no questions and on causal and relational questions, which have the longest answers (5.0 and 5.6 words). ViBridge-VQA (k=36) + LoRA is the best of the four models on seven of the eight types, all but yes/no.

Error analysis. Our answers are as long as the references (4.3 words on average). Most of them (77–81%) partially overlap the closest reference. Compared with Global-only, ViBridge-VQA raises exact matches (F1 = 1) from 9.7% to 13.3%. It lowers answers with no word in common with any reference from 9.6% to 8.0% (6.8% with LoRA).

Qualitative examples. Fig. 3 shows four validation examples. ViBridge-VQA already finds the relevant content, such as the driver's phone or the helmets, but its answers are vague. The decoder LoRA makes them precise: the driver is using *the phone*, and the helmets are worn *to protect their heads*.

Table 4: Cross-dataset results (mean ± std over three samples of about 1,000 test questions, one training seed). Best results per dataset are in bold. All values ×100.

Model	F1	BLEU	ROUGE-L	METEOR	CIDEr
ViTextVQA					
Vintern-1B, zero-shot	**32.01** ±.31	**4.94** ±.18	**20.89** ±.25	**26.50** ±.54	**195.62** ±2.35
Global-only + LoRA	3.96 ±.09	0.15 ±.01	3.74 ±.12	2.61 ±.16	15.64 ±.92
ViBridge-VQA (k=36) + LoRA	15.39 ±.39	1.03 ±.15	14.41 ±.33	11.17 ±.26	70.07 ±1.33
ViVQA-X					
Vintern-1B, zero-shot	14.52 ±.47	0.06 ±.01	8.98 ±.32	11.96 ±.41	50.13 ±2.83
Global-only + LoRA	15.89 ±.65	0.18 ±.02	11.94 ±.49	9.08 ±.57	42.12 ±2.92
ViBridge-VQA (k=36) + LoRA	**27.64** ±.11	**0.33** ±.05	**21.98** ±.13	**19.24** ±.14	**95.29** ±1.51
ViVQA					
Vintern-1B, zero-shot	23.90 ±.24	0.27 ±.02	15.78 ±.25	17.84 ±.19	78.63 ±2.07
Global-only + LoRA	31.48 ±1.15	0.25 ±.09	31.48 ±1.16	21.92 ±.82	84.94 ±2.87
ViBridge-VQA (k=36) + LoRA	**44.76** ±1.21	**0.63** ±.02	**44.74** ±1.22	**36.98** ±1.28	**183.60** ±7.17

4.7 Generalisation to Other Datasets

Table 4 tests the models on three Vietnamese VQA datasets not used for training. ViTextVQA [23] focuses on scene text, while ViVQA-X [8] and ViVQA [29] are general-domain datasets on COCO images. About 10% of their sampled questions concern images of our training split, with different questions. ViBridge-VQA (k=36) + LoRA beats Global-only + LoRA on all three datasets. It also beats the zero-shot Vintern-1B on ViVQA-X (27.64 versus 14.52 F1) and ViVQA (44.76 versus 23.90). On scene text, Vintern-1B stays ahead (32.01 versus 15.39), as it reads up to seven 448 × 448 views. Averaged over the three datasets, our model reaches 29.3 F1, against 23.5 for Vintern-1B.

5 Conclusion

In this work, we introduced **ViBridge-VQA**, which improves the Vietnamese VLM Vintern-1B for generative VQA without updating any of its pre-trained weights. Our results support three findings for a VLM whose projector is already aligned with its decoder. First, reusing this projector with a few pooled local tokens is more effective than learning a new connector from limited data. Second, the number of tokens can be chosen with an explicit accuracy–cost criterion. Third, the local tokens complement decoder adaptation rather than replace it.

Our study also has limitations. We train on a single dataset, AutoViVQA, and the task-specific ViMoE-VQA still reaches a higher F1. Without decoder adaptation, the exact-match accuracy of ViBridge-VQA stays below that of the fine-tuned Vintern-1B. With 50 visual tokens, it also reads scene text much worse than Vintern-1B. Finally, accuracy had not saturated at the 144 local tokens available at our resolution.

Overall, an existing Vietnamese VLM can be improved substantially by choosing which visual tokens its frozen decoder receives, and how many. The code and the image-disjoint split are available at `https://github.com/nguyennn263/modular-vlm-finetune`.

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